"To find yourself, think for yourself."
-Socrates

ACADEMIC WRITING:

SAMPLE ESSAY

Developed and compiled by
Michael Warrick

SAMPLE ESSAY: Describe core features of the UK University Education System

SCANNING

Decide whether the following statements are True (T) False (F) or Not Given (NG) according to the information given in the essay:

a)	UK universities combine research with the enhancement of academic skills.	**T / F / NG**
b)	Students attend lectures in order to debate issues	**T / F / NG**
c)	UK university students rely mainly on tutors for advice about reading selection	**T / F / NG**
d)	Students may use lecture notes during tutorials to defend and critique ideas.	**T / F / NG**
e)	Critical thinking is applied throughout a range of academic tasks	**T / F / NG**
f)	University lecturers adopt a more formal tone than high school teachers	**T / F / NG**
g)	A “2-1” degree is awarded for grades between 50% and 59%	**T / F / NG**
h)	International students are more likely to achieve a First than domestic students.	**T / F / NG**
i)	Few students are awarded a Distinction	**T / F / NG**

ESSAY TITLE: Describe core features of the UK University Education System

University education in the UK has a long and influential history, beginning with the establishment of Oxford in 1167 and Cambridge in 1209. Over time, British, higher-education institutions have developed a distinctive model of higher education that blends academic research with student skill development. The UK university system is designed to **a) cultivate** critical enquiry and intellectual independence - qualities that shape both the student experience and broader academic culture. This essay will examine how key elements of the university model - from teaching formats to assessment practices - are structured to promote active participation, critical reflection, and academic independence.

University teaching is typically delivered through three main class types, each with distinct functions. Lectures are large-scale sessions, often accommodating 200–300 students, in which information is presented by a lecturer while students listen and take notes. These are an efficient means of transmitting key concepts across a large **b) cohort**. Seminars are smaller, usually involving 10–15 students, and are structured around student-led presentations and subsequent discussions that allow for the exchange of ideas and the development of argumentation skills. Tutorials are smaller still - sometimes one-to-one - and are designed to intellectually challenge students, prompting them to think independently, **c) critique** arguments rigorously, and defend their viewpoints with evidence. This model of progressive engagement - from passive to interactive to personalized learning - reflects the pedagogical emphasis in UK universities on developing student **d) autonomy** through increasingly discussion-based formats (Norton, 2009).

Critical thinking and independent learning lie at the heart of UK higher education. These capacities are considered central to successful adjustment to university-level study and performance (Facione, 2015; Wingate, 2007). Critical thinking encompasses a broad spectrum of cognitive skills, such as the ability to identify assumptions, assess arguments, question **e) evidence**, and construct logical conclusions. They are embedded across all academic activities, from written assignments to presentations and research. In parallel, In parallel, students are encouraged to learn independently - an approach that requires **f) initiative** as well as the ability to take control of one's learning without continuous guidance. Core components of independent learning include time management, self-evaluation, and self-motivation - the internal drive to engage with learning beyond external rewards. As Qureshi *et al.* (2024) put it, "Self-motivation, grounded in intrinsic interest and personal relevance... enables students to pursue learning goals even in the absence of external incentives." This intrinsic orientation is crucial for sustaining academic effort in university contexts.

Relationships between tutors and students are relatively casual, and there is greater personal interaction than at secondary level. University students are viewed as emerging professionals, and the tone adopted by tutors reflects this shift in status. Informality in academic interactions is seen as a way to encourage openness, build rapport, and enhance intellectual exchange. Research indicates that such academic relationships contribute positively to students' sense of belonging and can act as a buffer against academic and social challenges during the transition into higher education (Yale, 2019). Regular opportunities for communication - such as through seminars, office hours, and meetings with personal tutors - enable students to raise academic or personal concerns in a supportive context. Furthermore, student input is increasingly valued in UK institutions, where it is understood that learning can be **g) reciprocal** tutors not only impart knowledge but also gain insight from students' unique perspectives.

In order to measure the success or failure of students for coursework and examinations, universities make use of a five-tier grading scale. The "fail" level is below 40%; the second level is a "third," which is 40% to 49%; the next level is a "2:2," representing 50% to 59%; and a "2:1" falls between 60% and 69%. A "first," or "distinction" (70% or above), signifies excellence, and is the highest award that a student can receive for a piece of work or for an exam result. For most disciplines, only a small minority of students, approximately 15%, obtain a first, and the majority of students are awarded marks in the 50's. Many international students initially find this system **h) disorienting**, especially those accustomed to achieving grades of 80% or 90% on average. However, it reflects the competitive nature and high expectations of UK higher education, where grades are designed primarily to **i) differentiate** levels of critical **j) engagement** and originality (Bloxham & Boyd, 2012).

REFERENCES

Bloxham, S. & Boyd, P. (2012) *Assessment and feedback in higher education: a guide for teachers*. Abingdon: Routledge.

Facione, P.A. (2015) *Critical thinking: what it is and why it counts*. Millbrae, CA: Insight Assessment. Available at: https://www.insightassessment.com/Resources/Importance-of-Critical-Thinking/Critical-Thinking-What-It-Is-and-Why-It-Counts (Accessed: 14 November 2025).

Norton, L. (2009) *Action research in teaching and learning: a practical guide to conducting pedagogical research in universities*. Abingdon: Routledge.

Times Higher Education (2024) *World university rankings: Cambridge profile*. Available at: https://www.timeshighereducation.com/world-university-rankings/university-cambridge (Accessed: 14 November 2025).

Wingate, U. (2007) A framework for transition: supporting "learning to learn" in higher education. *Higher Education Quarterly*, 61(3), pp. 391–405. doi:10.1111/j.1468-2273.2007.00361.x.

Yale, A.T. (2019) The personal tutor–student relationship: student expectations and experiences of personal tutoring in higher education. *Journal of Further and Higher Education*, 43(10), pp. 1321–1333. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1080/0309877X.2017.1377164

VOCABULARY

1. Find the following words in the essay above. Study the context in which they appear, then choose the best definition below:

a) cultivate (verb)
b) cohort (noun)
c) critique (verb)
d) autonomy
e) evidence (noun)
f) initiative (noun)
g) reciprocal (adj.)
h) disorienting (adj.)
i) differentiate (verb)
j) engagement (noun)

Definitions:

1) to grow or develop something intentionally (e.g., skills or relationships)
2) freedom and independence to make decisions
3) the ability or action of participating fully in something
4) to identify differences between two or more things
5) a group of individuals with shared characteristics, especially in education
6) mutual or two-way in nature
7) action taken to begin a task or process independently
8) to evaluate or discuss the strengths and weaknesses of an idea or argument
9) facts or information used to support a claim
10) confusing or unsettling due to unfamiliarity

2. Match the following words to the correct vocabulary term in exercise 1:

TERM	SYNONYM	TERM	SYNONYM
a) independence	.....	**f)** assess	.....
b) encourage	.....	**g)** self-starting approach	.....
c) data	.....	**h)** mutual	.....
d) distinguish	.....	**i)** involvement	.....
e) disconcerting	.....	**j)** group	.....

3. Fill in the blanks with the correct form of a word from *Exercise 1*. **You may need to adjust the form to fit the sentence:**

a) The university aims to *cultivate* habits of critical enquiry through both writing and class discussion.

b) It is expected that student learning will involve not just receiving knowledge but also _____ exchange with tutors.

c) Small-group teaching enables greater student _____ and peer collaboration.

d) To ensure fair assessment, the grading system is designed to _____ levels of performance and originality.

e) The lecture covered various types of statistical _____ used in educational research.

f) Many students experience the transition from school to university as _____, especially during the first semester.

g) Students are encouraged to take _____ in identifying their strengths and areas for development.

h) One of the most valued aspects of UK higher education is the level of academic _____ students are given.

i) The tutor asked the class to _____ the main arguments of the article and identify any logical fallacies.

j) A research _____ was surveyed to analyse trends in independent learning habits.